

of the seed's close resemblance to a male testicle... [ancient Egyptians] made it an object of sacred worship and forbade its use as a food."

Medicinal Actions & Uses In addition to being an important food in many parts of the world, French beans, and beans in general, offer several health benefits. As part of a balanced nutritious diet, they help to lower high blood pressure and raised cholesterol levels. They are hypoglycemic and promote more stable blood-sugar levels. Like soy (*Glycine max*, p. 217), they are estrogenic and will help reduce menopausal symptoms. The pods act as a medium-strength diuretic, stimulating urine flow and the clearance of toxins from the body. Powdered beans may be dusted onto eczema to ease itching and dry skin.



French beans are intensively cultivated all over the world.

Phellodendron amurense (Rutaceae)

Huang Bai

Description Deciduous tree growing to 39 ft (12 m). Has compound leaves with 7 lance-shaped leaflets, clusters of green flowers, and round berries.

Habitat & Cultivation *Huang bai* is native to China, Japan, and Korea, and is cultivated in northeastern China. The bark of 10-year-old trees is collected in spring.

Part Used Bark.

Constituents *Huang bai* contains isoquinoline alkaloids (including berberine), sesquiterpene lactones, and plant sterols. Due to its alkaloid content, *huang bai* is antimicrobial and antibiotic.

History & Folklore Listed in the *Divine Husbandman's Classic* (*Shen'nong Bencaojing*), of the 1st century CE, *huang bai* was regarded as an herb to be used with care.

Medicinal Actions & Uses Strongly bitter, *huang bai* is used within Chinese herbal medicine to "drain damp heat." It is prescribed for conditions

such as acute diarrhea, jaundice, vaginal infection (including trichomonas), and certain skin conditions. It is also given for urinary system disorders such as frequent urination, pain, and infection.

Research Clinical trials in China indicate that the bark is useful in the treatment of meningitis and conjunctivitis.

⚠ **Cautions** Take *huang bai* only under professional supervision. Do not take *huang bai* during pregnancy.

Phyllanthus amarus (Euphorbiaceae)

Phyllanthus

Description Slender annual herb, to 2 ft (60 cm) in height, with oval leaves and small yellowish-green flowers.

Habitat & Cultivation *Phyllanthus* is native to the Indian subcontinent and found commonly in central and southern India. The plant is harvested when required.

Parts Used Leaves, aerial parts.

Constituents *Phyllanthus* leaves contain lignans (including phyllanthin and hypophyllanthin), flavonoids, and alkaloids.

Medicinal Actions & Uses *Phyllanthus* is a traditional Ayurvedic remedy used to treat liver and cardiovascular problems. It combines well with *picrorrhiza* (*Picrorrhiza kurroa*, p. 248) in treating hepatitis B and other liver disorders.

Research A growing body of research shows that *phyllanthus* has antiviral activity, specifically against the hepatitis B virus. Research also indicates that the leaves are diuretic, and lower blood pressure and blood-sugar levels. Not all the studies have shown that *phyllanthus* works effectively in treating hepatitis B, but overall the evidence is positive, with some trials showing significant improvement in measures of infection. In laboratory experiments, *phyllanthus* inhibits RNA replication of the hepatitis B virus.

⚠ **Caution** Use on professional advice only.

Physalis alkekengi syn. P. franchetti (Solanaceae)

Winter Cherry, Cape Gooseberry

Description Perennial herb growing to 32 in (80 cm). Has oval- to diamond-shaped leaves, long-stemmed white flowers, and a translucent papery sheath surrounding an orange-red fruit.

Habitat & Cultivation Winter cherry is native to central and southern Europe and China. It grows wild along damp roadsides. It is widely

cultivated in warm temperate and subtropical regions, including North and South America and South Africa. The fruit is gathered once it has ripened in summer.

Parts Used Fruit.

Constituents Winter cherry contains flavonoids, plant sterols, and vitamins A (carotene) and C. The roots contain tropane-type alkaloids, physalin A and B. Water extracts of the plant may have an anti-estrogenic effect.

History & Folklore The Greek physician Dioscorides (1st century CE) considered winter cherry to be medicinally beneficial as a diuretic and a treatment for jaundice. In Spain, a therapeutic wine made with the fruit was taken to treat excess fluid retention and problems of the urinary tract.

Medicinal Actions & Uses Though commonly eaten as a fruit, winter cherry is also a useful diuretic. The fruit is traditionally used within European herbal medicine to treat kidney and bladder stones, fluid retention, and gout. It has also been taken to reduce fever.

Caution The foliage and unripe fruit are harmful if eaten.

Phytolacca americana syn. P. decandra (Phytolaccaceae) Pokeweed

Description Herbaceous perennial growing to 10 ft (3 m). Has alternate lance-shaped leaves, spikes of greenish-white flowers, and clusters of fleshy, purple berries.

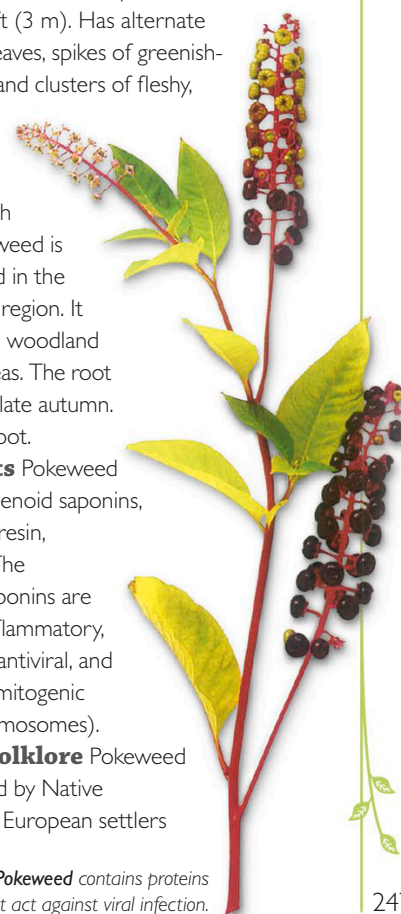
Habitat & Cultivation

Native to North America, pokeweed is now naturalized in the Mediterranean region. It thrives in damp woodland and in open areas. The root is unearthed in late autumn.

Part Used Root.

Constituents Pokeweed contains triterpenoid saponins, lectins, lignans, resin, and mucilage. The triterpenoid saponins are strongly anti-inflammatory, the lignans are antiviral, and the lectins are mitogenic (break up chromosomes).

History & Folklore Pokeweed was widely used by Native Americans and European settlers



Pokeweed contains proteins that act against viral infection.